WILMINGTON DELAWARE STAKE RESOURCE GUIDE

Free Legal Help

Family, Divorce, Custody and Abuse

Families · Single Men and Fathers · Single Women and Mothers
Divorce · Custody · Child Support · Protective Orders · Abuse

Wilmington Delaware Stake
Cecil · Harford · Kent, Maryland
New Castle, Delaware · Lancaster · Chester, Pennsylvania
October 2026

> *...what doth the Lord require of thee, but to do justly, and to love mercy, and to walk humbly with thy God?*
> — Micah 6:8

Not legal advice. Court deadlines are strict — get help early. In danger? Call 911.

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How to Use This Guide

This guide covers the six counties of the Wilmington Delaware Stake in three states. You file divorce, custody and support cases in the state and county where you (or your children) live, so turn to your county's section. Every county has at least one free place to get forms and a short talk with a lawyer, even if your income is too high for legal aid.

> *Learn to do well; seek judgment, relieve the oppressed, judge the fatherless, plead for the widow.*
>
> — Isaiah 1:17

If you or your children are in danger, call 911. For a 24/7 abuse hotline in your county, see *Safety First* — the hotline can help you get a protective order, shelter, and a free lawyer.

If you live in	Free walk-in or phone help first	Free lawyer (income-qualified)	If there is abuse (24/7)
Cecil County, MD	Family Law Clinic, Circuit Court, Elkton · 410-996-1157	Maryland Legal Aid · 410-836-8202	The Bridge · 410-996-0333
Harford County, MD	Family Law Self-Help Center, Bel Air · 410-638-4916	Maryland Legal Aid · 410-836-8202	SARC · 410-836-8430
Kent County, MD	Family Law Clinic, Chestertown · 443-666-4327	Shore Legal Access · 410-690-8128	Mid-Shore Council on Family Violence · 1-800-927-4673
New Castle County, DE	Family Court Self-Help Center, Wilmington · 302-255-0476	DVLS · 302-478-8680 (abuse cases)	DV Hotline · 302-762-6110
Lancaster County, PA	Self-Help Center, Courthouse, 50 N. Duke St	MidPenn Legal Services · 1-800-326-9177	DV Services of Lancaster County · 717-299-1249
Chester County, PA	Prothonotary custody packet · 610-344-6300	Legal Aid of Southeastern PA · 877-429-5994	DV Center of Chester County · 888-711-6270

Any state: **2-1-1** connects you to local help.

Who This Guide Is For

- **Families** — parents, grandparents and relatives raising children, families with a member who has a disability, older adults, and immigrant families. See *Resources for Families*.
- **Single men and fathers** — paternity, custody and parenting time, child support changes, fatherhood programs, and men who have experienced abuse. See *Resources for Single Men and Fathers*.

- **Single women and mothers** — women's legal hotlines, workplace and pregnancy rights, support, name changes, and survivors' services. See *Resources for Single Women and Mothers*.
- **Anyone facing abuse** — protective orders, hotlines, sexual assault centers, child and elder abuse reporting, and confidentiality programs. See *Safety First*.

Kinds of Free Legal Help

Type	What you get	Who qualifies
Hotline or chat	A lawyer answers questions by phone; no court appearance	Anyone
Court self-help center or clinic	Forms, filing help, a short meeting with a lawyer	Anyone, or income-screened (varies)
Limited help ("brief advice")	A lawyer reviews your papers or coaches you for a hearing	Usually low-income
Full representation	A lawyer handles your case and goes to court with you	Low-income, or abuse survivors (often regardless of income)
Bar referral	A first meeting with a private lawyer at a reduced fee ($35–$50)	Anyone; later fees are paid

Legal aid offices have long waiting lists for divorce and custody. Apply to more than one program at once, and use the court self-help center while you wait.

> **About this guide.** Compiled by volunteers of the Wilmington Delaware Stake as a free community service for anyone in Cecil, Harford and Kent counties (Maryland), New Castle County (Delaware), and Lancaster and Chester counties (Pennsylvania). It is not an official publication of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, and listing an organization is not an endorsement. It is not legal advice and does not create a lawyer–client relationship. Information was checked in October 2026, but programs, phone numbers, hours, dollar amounts and rules change often. Always call to confirm before you travel, apply or rely on any figure. Every program listed serves people of any faith or no faith.

Before You Call

> *Blessed are the peacemakers: for they shall be called the children of God.*
>
> — Matthew 5:9

First Steps

- **Call legal aid now,** before papers are filed if you can. Intake lines are open only certain hours, and waits can be weeks.
- **If you were served with court papers, note the deadline.** Maryland gives 30 days to answer a complaint (60 if served out of state); Delaware and Pennsylvania generally give 20 days to respond to a divorce complaint, and custody papers set a conference date you must attend. Missing it can let the other side win by default.
- **Do not move out of state with the children or keep them from the other parent** without a court order or legal advice. It can hurt your custody case.
- **Apply for child support separately.** The state child support office will establish and collect support for free, with or without a lawyer (see your county section).
- **Ask for a fee waiver** if you cannot pay court costs. Every court in this guide has one.
- **Talk with your bishop** if you would like spiritual support or help finding counseling. Church leaders can offer support and referrals, but they cannot give legal advice.

Papers to Gather

- Photo ID, and birth certificates and Social Security numbers for the children
- Marriage certificate, and any existing custody, support or protective orders
- Court papers you have been served with, including the case number
- Proof of your income: last 30 days of pay stubs, benefit letters, tax return
- The other parent’s address, employer and income, if you know them
- Child care, health insurance and school costs for the children
- A calendar or notes of who has cared for the children, and when
- Texts, emails, photos or police reports about any abuse or threats (keep copies somewhere safe)

Income Limits at a Glance

Each program sets its own limit. These are gross **yearly** household income limits for 2026; call even if you are slightly over, since assets, expenses and abuse can change the answer.

Household size	125% FPL (MidPenn, many legal aid programs)	200% FPL	50% of MD median (MVLS, Harford Bar Foundation)
1	$19,950	$31,920	$41,129
2	$27,050	$43,280	$53,784
3	$34,150	$54,640	$66,439
4	$41,250	$66,000	$79,094
5	$48,350	$77,360	$91,748
6	$55,450	$88,720	$104,403

FPL figures are calculated from the 2026 HHS poverty guidelines ($15,960 for one person plus $5,680 per added person). Maryland figures are from MVLS for July 2026 – June 2027. Survivors of domestic violence often qualify regardless of income.

Safety First: Abuse and Protective Orders

If you or your children are being threatened or hurt, a protective order can come first and fast — often the same day. It can order the abuser to stay away and move out, and can award temporary custody and support. There is **no filing fee** in any of the three states, and you do not need a lawyer to file. Abuse is never the victim's fault, and help is available to women, men, teens, older adults, and people of every background.

> *The Church's position is that abuse cannot be tolerated in any form.*
>
> — General Handbook of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, 38.6.2

24/7 Domestic Violence Programs

These programs give free legal help, not just shelter. Several have their own attorneys who represent survivors in protective order hearings and in custody, divorce and support cases. Call to confirm services for men; national hotlines serve everyone.

County	Program	24/7 hotline	What they do
Cecil, MD	The Bridge (Domestic Violence Rape Crisis Center)	410-996-0333	Court advocacy, legal representation at protective order hearings, shelter, counseling, hospital accompaniment
Harford, MD	SARC	410-836-8430	Free attorneys for protective orders, divorce, custody and child support; court accompaniment; safety planning
Kent, MD	Mid-Shore Council on Family Violence	1-800-927-4673	Legal representation for protective orders, divorce and custody; reduced-fee custody project
New Castle, DE	Delaware DV hotline (English and Spanish)	302-762-6110	Shelter, advocacy, help filing a PFA; Family Court DV advocates 302-255-0420
Lancaster, PA	Domestic Violence Services of Lancaster County (CAP)	717-299-1249	Protective-order help, court accompaniment, legal representation, custody help (English and Spanish)
Chester, PA	Domestic Violence Center of Chester County	888-711-6270	Three staff attorneys for PFA hearings; advice on custody, divorce and support

How to Get a Protective Order

State	Order is called	Where to file	After hours
Maryland	Protective Order (petition for protection)	Circuit or District Court clerk, any county courthouse	District Court Commissioner (24/7)
Delaware	Protection from Abuse (PFA)	Family Court, or email forms to FC_PFA@delaware.gov	Call police; next-morning hearing
Pennsylvania	Protection from Abuse (PFA)	Court of Common Pleas (Lancaster: Bail Administration; Chester: Justice Center, West Chester)	Emergency PFA through the on-call magisterial district judge

- **Mediation** is usually not required when there is abuse or a protective order. Tell the court and your mediator about any abuse.
- **Firearms:** protective orders in all three states can require the abuser to surrender firearms. Tell the judge if the abuser has guns.
- **Keep a copy of your order with you** and give copies to your children's school or child care.

Sexual Assault Help

County	Program	24/7 line
Cecil, MD	The Bridge	410-996-0333
Harford, MD	SARC	410-836-8430
Kent, MD	For All Seasons (Chestertown office, 315 High St)	410-820-5600 · Spanish call or text 410-829-6143
Maryland statewide	Sexual Assault Legal Institute (free legal services for survivors)	301-565-2277 / 877-496-7254
New Castle, DE	YWCA Delaware Sexual Assault Response Center (ages 12+)	1-800-773-8570
Lancaster, PA	YWCA Lancaster Sexual Assault Prevention & Counseling Center	717-392-7273
Chester, PA	Crime Victims' Center of Chester County	610-692-7273
Anywhere	RAINN National Sexual Assault Hotline	1-800-656-4673 · text HOPE to 64673

Reporting Child Abuse or Neglect

State	Call (24/7)
Maryland (Cecil, Harford, Kent)	1-800-917-7383 (1-800-91-PREVENT)
Delaware	1-800-292-9582
Pennsylvania	ChildLine 1-800-932-0313

If a child is in immediate danger, call 911 first.

Abuse of Older or Vulnerable Adults

State	Adult Protective Services
Maryland	1-800-917-7383
Delaware	1-888-277-4302 (nursing homes and care facilities: 1-877-453-0012)
Pennsylvania	Elder Abuse Helpline 1-800-490-8505 (24/7)

Keeping Your Address Private

Address Confidentiality Programs give survivors a substitute address for court papers, voter records and many agencies.

- **Maryland Safe at Home:** 410-260-3875 · sos.maryland.gov/ACP
- **Delaware Address Confidentiality Program** (Department of Justice): ask DOJ Victim Services, 1-800-870-1790, or your DV advocate.
- **Pennsylvania Address Confidentiality Program:** 1-800-563-6399 (Mon–Fri 8–4).
- **Name changes for survivors:** courts can waive newspaper publication and seal records for safety (Chester County has a specific order form; ask your advocate in any county).

Crime Victim Compensation

Pays for costs such as counseling, medical bills, lost wages, relocation and lock changes after a crime.

State	Program	Phone
Maryland	Criminal Injuries Compensation Board	410-585-3010 / 888-679-9347
Delaware	Victims' Compensation Assistance Program (VCAP)	302-255-1770
Pennsylvania	Victims Compensation Assistance Program	1-800-233-2339 · dave.pa.gov

Know when an offender is released: Maryland VINE 1-866-634-8463; Pennsylvania SAVIN 1-866-972-7284; Delaware and all states at vinelink.com.

National Hotlines (24/7)

- **National Domestic Violence Hotline:** 1-800-799-7233 · text START to 88788 · serves women and men.
- **Love Is Respect** (teens and young adults, dating abuse): 1-866-331-9474 · text LOVEIS to 22522.
- **National Human Trafficking Hotline:** 1-888-373-7888 · text 233733.
- **StrongHearts Native Helpline:** 1-844-762-8483.
- **PA SafeLaw** (free legal information and referrals for abuse victims statewide): 1-833-727-2335.

A Basic Safety Plan

- Keep a charged phone, important papers (IDs, birth certificates, orders, medications) and some cash in one place you can grab quickly, or with a trusted person.
- Choose a safe place to go and a code word for friends or family that means “call for help.”
- Use a safer device for research; clear browser history if your phone or computer may be checked.
- Write down what happened, with dates, and save photos and messages somewhere the abuser cannot reach.
- Your county’s DV program will help you make a detailed plan, including for children and pets.

> *He healeth the broken in heart, and bindeth up their wounds.*
>
> — Psalm 147:3

How the Three States Differ

> *Discourage litigation. Persuade your neighbors to compromise whenever you can. Point out to them how the nominal winner is often a real loser—in fees, expenses, and waste of time.*
>
> — Abraham Lincoln, notes for a law lecture, c. 1850

	Maryland	Delaware	Pennsylvania
Court	Circuit Court (family division)	Family Court	Court of Common Pleas
Divorce grounds	Mutual consent (signed settlement, no wait), 6-month separation (can be under one roof), or irreconcilable differences (no wait); fault grounds ended for cases filed from Oct 1, 2023	Marriage "irretrievably broken": 6-month separation, and incompatibility, or misconduct	Mutual consent (90 days after service), or 1 year living separate and apart
Residency to file divorce	None if grounds arose in MD; otherwise 6 months	6 months	6 months
Custody words	Legal custody (big decisions) and physical custody (where the child lives); sole, joint or shared	Joint or sole legal custody, plus primary residence and a visitation schedule	Legal and physical custody; shared, primary, partial, sole or supervised
First step in a custody case	Scheduling conference; mediation often ordered	Mediation after the petition is served	Custody conciliation conference before a court officer
Required parenting class	Ordered by the court; $25 online in Harford and Kent	Required for custody and divorce with children; up to $100	Required: "Focus on Children" (Lancaster), "Children in Between" (Chester)
Divorce filing fee	$165	$165 + $10 security fee	About $214–$237 (varies by county)
Fee waiver form	CC-DC-089, Request for Waiver of Prepaid Costs	Form 257P, Application to Proceed In Forma Pauperis	Petition to Proceed In Forma Pauperis (county packet)
Child support agency	Child Support Administration, 1-800-332-6347	Division of Child Support Services, 302-577-7171	County Domestic Relations Section
Name change filed in	Circuit Court (forms CC-DR-60 adult, CC-DR-062 minor; $165)	Court of Common Pleas	Court of Common Pleas

Resources for Families

Help for parents, grandparents and relatives raising children, families caring for someone with a disability, older adults, and immigrant families.

> *Husband and wife have a solemn responsibility to love and care for each other and for their children.*
>
> — "The Family: A Proclamation to the World" (1995)

Grandparents and Relatives Raising Children (Kinship Care)

State	Help	Contact
Maryland	Kinship Navigator — explains benefits such as the TCA child-only grant, SNAP and child care	Dial 211 or text MDKinCares to 898-211
Delaware	Kinship Care Program (DSS) — urgent needs in the first 180 days after a child moves in; relative within the 5th degree; income under 200% FPL	302-255-9040 · apply on ASSIST
Pennsylvania	KinConnector — information and referral helpline	1-866-546-2111 (1-866-KIN-2111) · kinconnector.org
Pennsylvania	Grandparents Raising Grandchildren Legal Line (SeniorLAW Center) — free legal advice on custody and kinship issues, all 67 counties	1-877-727-7529

A relative can usually seek custody or guardianship of a child in the family's care. Ask legal aid in your county about third-party custody, guardianship and standby guardianship.

Child Support for Any Parent

- The state child support agency opens a case, finds the other parent, establishes paternity and support, and collects payments at no cost: Maryland 1-800-332-6347; Delaware 302-577-7171; Lancaster Domestic Relations 717-299-8141; Chester Domestic Relations 610-344-6215. Pennsylvania applications can also be filed online at childsupport.state.pa.us.
- Support is set by state guidelines based on both parents' incomes, the number of children, child care and health insurance.
- **If income changes, ask for a change right away.** Past-due support usually can't be reduced later. See the men's and women's sections for details.

Mediation and Co-Parenting

- Most custody cases start with mediation or a conference. A neutral mediator helps parents write their own parenting plan. Mediation is usually skipped where there is abuse.

- Every county requires or offers a parenting class; details are in each county section.
- Put agreements in writing and have them made into a court order so they can be enforced.

Families with a Child or Adult Who Has a Disability

State	Organization	Phone
Maryland	The Parents' Place of Maryland (special education and health information)	1-800-394-5694 / 410-768-9100
Maryland	Disability Rights Maryland	410-727-6352 / 1-800-233-7201
Delaware	Parent Information Center of Delaware, 100 W. 10th St., Suite 1008, Wilmington	302-999-7394 / 888-547-4412
Delaware	Disability Rights Delaware (CLASI)	302-575-0690
Pennsylvania	PEAL Center (family support, IEP help)	866-950-1040
Pennsylvania	Disability Rights Pennsylvania	1-800-692-7443

Older Adults (60+)

State	Free legal help	Phone
Maryland	Maryland Legal Aid senior legal services (60+) — ask at intake	1-888-465-2468
Delaware	CLASI Elder Law Program (60+): powers of attorney, advance directives, housing, benefits	302-575-0666
Pennsylvania	SeniorLAW HelpLine (60+), Mon–Thu 10–12	1-877-727-7529
Chester County	Free 30-minute attorney consultations for low-income seniors, 2nd Monday each month (Dept. of Aging Services)	610-344-6350

Parents in a Child Welfare (CPS) Case

If child protective services is involved with your family, you have the right to a lawyer, and the court appoints one if you can't afford it.

- **Maryland:** Office of the Public Defender, Parental Defense Division — 1-877-430-5187.
- **Delaware:** Family Court appoints counsel in most dependency/neglect cases; CLASI's Family Representation Unit — 302-575-0660.
- **Pennsylvania:** ask the court for a court-appointed lawyer at your first hearing; MidPenn or LASP can explain the process.

Immigrant Families (Nonprofit Legal Help)

Beware of "notarios" and anyone who is not a licensed attorney or DOJ-accredited representative.

Area	Organization	Phone
Delaware, Cecil and Kent	Catholic Charities, Diocese of Wilmington, Immigration Legal Services, 2601 W. 4th St., Wilmington	302-655-9624
Maryland (Baltimore area)	Catholic Charities Esperanza Center (free for crime, trafficking and DV victims and minors)	667-600-2941
Lancaster	Church World Service Lancaster, Immigration Legal Services, 308 E. King St.	717-358-9728
Chester (Kennett Square)	LCH Health & Community Services (La Comunidad Hispana) — form help, Spanish-speaking	610-880-3503

Survivors of domestic violence or certain crimes may qualify for protections (VAWA, U visa, T visa). Ask your DV program for a referral.

Resources for Single Men and Fathers

Fathers matter to their children, and courts in all three states start from the view that children benefit from both parents. These resources help men establish fatherhood, stay involved with their children, keep support orders fair, and get help if they have been abused.

> *And he shall turn the heart of the fathers to the children, and the heart of the children to their fathers…*
>
> — Malachi 4:6

If You Are Not Married to the Child's Mother: Paternity First

An unmarried father is not the legal father until paternity is established — by signing a voluntary acknowledgment (often at the hospital) or by court order.

State	How	Key facts
Maryland	Affidavit of Parentage	Either parent can cancel within 60 days; after that only for fraud, duress or material mistake. It does not give custody or visitation by itself — you may petition the court for custody or visitation.
Delaware	Voluntary Acknowledgement of Paternity (VAP) — at the hospital, any DCSS or Vital Statistics office, or by mail with a notary	Can be signed until the child turns 18. "A VAP does not automatically give the father visitation or custody rights." DCSS New Castle 302-577-7171
Pennsylvania	Acknowledgment of Paternity (form PA-CS 611) — at the hospital, or from DHS at 1-800-932-0211	Revocable within 60 days. To seek custody, file the acknowledgment with the court; if the mother disagrees, file a Complaint to Establish Paternity and for Genetic Testing.

Bottom line: signing establishes legal fatherhood, but to have enforceable custody or parenting time, a father needs a **court custody order**. File in the county where the child lives, using the self-help center or legal aid listed in your county section.

Custody and Parenting Time

- Courts decide custody based on the child's best interests, not on which parent is the mother or father.
- Keep a calendar of the time you spend with your children, the care you provide, and your communication with the other parent.
- Pay support through the official agency so there is a record; never stop paying because you aren't seeing your child — those are separate issues for the court.
- Stay respectful in texts and emails. Judges read them.

- Free lawyers and clinics in your county section help fathers as well as mothers.

Child Support: Job Loss, Changes and Arrears

State	What to do	Help with past-due support
Maryland	File a motion to modify in Circuit Court as soon as income changes (a change of about 25% is usually enough). If your case is with the agency, you can ask for a review every 3 years.	**Payment Incentive Program:** one year of full payments cuts state-owed arrears in half; two years can erase them (income under 225% FPL). Call 1-800-332-6347.
Delaware	File a petition in Family Court; DCSS can help (302-577-7171). Allowed after 2.5 years, or sooner after job loss or another big change.	**Delaware Fatherhood Program** (302-577-7171) may offer, case by case, state debt reduction, license reinstatement or order modification for parents who are unemployed, recently released, or behind.
Pennsylvania	File a petition to modify online (humanservices.dhs.pa.gov/csws) or at Domestic Relations (Lancaster 717-299-8141; Chester 610-344-6215). No advance filing fee for support actions.	Ask Domestic Relations about payment plans and job programs.

Past-due support generally can't be reduced after the fact, so file for a change the moment your income drops.

Fatherhood and Job Programs

Area	Program	Contact
Cecil and Kent, MD	Mid-Shore RISE Program (Child Support Administration) — job training and placement, certifications, help with transportation, work clothes and tools for parents who owe support	410-200-6261
Harford, MD	Maryland Child Support help line (ask about employment programs)	1-800-332-6347
Delaware	Delaware Fatherhood Program (DCSS, with DSS and Labor) — job placement, trade certificates, financial education, mentoring, case help	302-577-7171
Delaware	Delaware Fatherhood & Family Coalition, 1825 Faulkland Rd., Wilmington — workshops, co-parenting support	855-733-3232 · dffcdads.org
Lancaster, PA	Community Action Partnership — Promoting Responsible Fatherhood (support group, "Dads in Training," "Long Distance Dads" for incarcerated fathers)	601 S. Queen St. · 717-299-7301 (main line)
Chester, PA	Family Service of Chester County — Exchange Club Family Center (parenting classes and support)	610-969-4900
All counties	Your county job center (see the stake's *Finding Work* guide)	—

> *Fatherhood requires sacrifice, but it is a source of incomparable satisfaction, even joy.*
>
> — Elder D. Todd Christofferson, "Fathers," general conference, April 2016

Men Who Have Experienced Abuse

Men can be victims of domestic violence, sexual assault and stalking, and they have the same right to a protective order.

- **National Domestic Violence Hotline:** 1-800-799-7233 — serves men.
- **RAINN:** 1-800-656-4673 — sexual assault, any gender.
- **1in6.org** — free online support groups for men who experienced sexual abuse or assault.
- **County DV and sexual assault programs** (see *Safety First*) serve "victims and survivors"; call and ask about services for men.

Single Men Without Children

- **Divorce:** use the court self-help center and the "How the Three States Differ" table. A simple mutual-consent divorce with no children and no property disputes is often possible without a lawyer.
- **Protective orders:** available to anyone abused by a current or former spouse, partner, household member, or (in some cases) someone you dated.
- **Records and second chances:** see the stake's *Finding Work* guide for record clearing and reentry help.

Resources for Single Women and Mothers

These resources help women protect themselves and their children, secure support, and understand their rights at work and in court.

> *Strength and honour are her clothing; and she shall rejoice in time to come.*
>
> — Proverbs 31:25

Women’s Legal Hotlines and Organizations

Area	Organization	Contact
Maryland	Women’s Law Center Family Law Hotline — a lawyer answers divorce and custody questions, anonymously	1-800-845-8550 (Mon–Fri 9:30–4:30); Spanish 1-877-293-2507
Maryland	Women’s Law Center Employment Law Hotline — discrimination, harassment, pay, FMLA, pregnancy protections	1-877-422-9500 (Tuesdays 9:30–1; 1st and 3rd Thursdays 5–7:30)
Maryland	Women’s Law Center main intake	410-321-8761
Delaware	YWCA Delaware (housing, Sexual Assault Response Center)	302-658-7110 · SARC 1-800-773-8570
Delaware	DVLS — free lawyers for survivors (PFA, custody where there is abuse, first divorce papers)	302-478-8680
Pennsylvania	Women’s Law Project (public-interest law; informational brochures on paternity, support, custody)	215-928-9801 · womenslawproject.org
Lancaster	YWCA Lancaster (housing, sexual assault counseling)	717-393-1735 · 24/7 717-392-7273

Pregnancy and Work

- The federal **Pregnant Workers Fairness Act** requires covered employers to make reasonable accommodations for pregnancy, childbirth and related conditions (for example, breaks, a stool, schedule changes, or leave) unless it causes undue hardship.
- File a complaint with the EEOC: 1-800-669-4000, or ask the Women’s Law Center Employment Law Hotline.
- Pregnant women and new mothers can get WIC and Medicaid; see the stake’s *Community Assistance* guide.

Support for You and Your Children

- **Child support:** open a case with the state agency at no cost (see *Resources for Families*). You do not need a lawyer, and you can ask the agency to locate the other

parent and establish paternity.

- **Alimony / spousal support:** in Maryland, alimony generally must be requested *before* the divorce is final — ask for it in your divorce case. In Pennsylvania, spousal support and alimony pending divorce are filed through Domestic Relations with no advance fee. In Delaware, ask the Family Court Self-Help Center about alimony forms ($90 filing fee).
- **Health insurance for the children:** support orders usually address it; Medicaid and CHIP cover many children.

Name Changes

- **Maryland:** file in Circuit Court (form CC-DR-60 for adults; CC-DR-062 for minors); fee $165, waivers available. You can also ask to resume a prior name in your divorce.
- **Delaware:** file in the Court of Common Pleas; packets are online at courts.delaware.gov.
- **Pennsylvania:** file in the Court of Common Pleas. Survivors can ask the court to waive publication and seal the records.

Safety and Healing

- Your county's DV program (see *Safety First*) can help you get a protective order, shelter, a lawyer, and counseling for you and your children.
- **Maryland Safe at Home**, the **Delaware** and **Pennsylvania Address Confidentiality Programs** keep your new address private.
- Bishops can help arrange counseling through Family Services and short-term support for your family.

> *We need women who know how to make important things happen by their faith and who are courageous defenders of morality and families in a sin-sick world.*
>
> — President Russell M. Nelson, "A Plea to My Sisters," general conference, October 2015

Cecil County, Maryland

Start at the **Family Law Clinic** in the Cecil County Circuit Court, 129 East Main Street, Elkton, MD 21921. Call Family Support Services at 410-996-1157 to confirm clinic hours (they change) and book a time. This section also lists the statewide Maryland programs that serve Harford and Kent too.

> *I need thee ev'ry hour,*
> *Most gracious Lord.*
> *No tender voice like thine*
> *Can peace afford.*
>
> — "I Need Thee Every Hour," *Hymns*, no. 98

Court Self-Help

- **Family Law Clinic:** a lawyer helps income-eligible people who cannot afford an attorney with forms and advice on divorce, custody, visitation, child support and protective orders. It does not represent you in court.
- **Maryland Court Help Center:** free lawyers by phone at 410-260-1392 or live chat at mdcourts.gov/selfhelp, Mon–Fri 8:30 a.m.–8 p.m. Anyone can use it, at any income.
- **Clerk's office, civil/domestic:** 410-996-5377 or 410-996-5378, Mon–Fri 8:30–4:30. Clerks can take filings and explain fees but cannot give legal advice.
- **Free forms and how-to guides:** mdcourts.gov/family and the People's Law Library (peoples-law.org).

Free Lawyers

Program	What it does	How to apply
Maryland Legal Aid, Northeastern office, 103 S. Hickory Ave, Bel Air	Custody cases and domestic violence safety for low-income residents	410-836-8202 (Tue–Thu 10–12 for Cecil intake), or 1-888-465-2468 Mon–Fri 9–2:30, or online at mdlab.org
Maryland Volunteer Lawyers Service (MVLS)	Full representation by volunteer lawyers: custody, divorce, support	Family cases by phone only: 1-800-510-0050, Mon–Thu 9–12. Income up to 50% of MD median; $25 fee, waived below poverty level
Harford County Bar Foundation	Judicare (reduced-cost lawyers) for custody and divorce; free phone and library advice clinics. Serves Cecil and Harford	410-836-0123; same income limit as MVLS
Women's Law Center Family Law Hotline	A lawyer answers divorce and custody questions, anonymously	1-800-845-8550, Mon–Fri 9:30–4:30

Abuse and Protective Orders

The Bridge (Cecil County's Domestic Violence Rape Crisis Center), 410-996-0333, 24/7. Free court advocacy and accompaniment, legal representation at protective order hearings, safe shelter and counseling.

Child Support

Child Support Administration, 170 East Main Street, Elkton (same building as DSS). Customer service 1-800-332-6347; automated payment line 1-844-324-3855. Fathers who owe support may qualify for the **Mid-Shore RISE** job program (410-200-6261).

Mediation and Parenting Classes

Family Support Services (410-996-1157) runs the court's family programs:

- **Custody and visitation mediation:** a neutral mediator helps parents write their own parenting plan. Not used where there is abuse.
- **Parenting classes** (online, when ordered): 6-hour co-parenting/divorce class; 12-hour "Parenting Without Conflict" for high-conflict families; 12-hour parenting skills by child age. Ask FSS for discount codes.
- **Custody evaluations** by licensed social workers and psychologists, when the court orders them.

Court Costs

The divorce or custody filing fee is $165. If you cannot pay, file form CC-DC-089, Request for Waiver of Prepaid Costs, with your papers. The clinic or Help Center can help you fill it out.

Cecil County Contacts

Need	Phone
Family Law Clinic / Family Support Services	410-996-1157
Maryland Court Help Center	410-260-1392
Maryland Legal Aid (local)	410-836-8202
MVLS family law intake	1-800-510-0050
Family Law Hotline	1-800-845-8550
The Bridge (abuse, 24/7)	410-996-0333
Child support	1-800-332-6347
Child abuse report	1-800-917-7383
Department of Social Services	410-996-0100

Harford County, Maryland

Start at the **Family Law Self-Help Center**, Harford County Circuit Court, 20 W. Courtland St, Bel Air, MD 21014, 410-638-4916. Harford uses the same Maryland laws, forms, fees and statewide programs as Cecil County; see the Cecil section for MVLS, the Court Help Center and the Family Law Hotline.

> *A father of the fatherless, and a judge of the widows, is God in his holy habitation.*
>
> — Psalm 68:5

Court Self-Help

- **Family Law Self-Help Center:** Level A (one floor below the entrance; take the elevator after security). Weekdays 9:00–4:00. Staff book 30-minute meetings and return calls within 24 hours.
- It helps with forms for divorce, custody, child support and protective orders; filing and checking case status; reviewing papers for completeness; fee waivers; and how to serve the other parent. Interpreters (including sign language) are available. It does not give legal advice or go to court with you.
- **After hours:** petitions for protection go to the District Court Commissioner at the Harford County Detention Center, 1030 Rock Spring Rd, Bel Air.

Free Lawyers

Program	What it does	How to apply
Maryland Legal Aid, Northeastern office, 103 S. Hickory Ave, Bel Air	Custody cases and domestic violence safety for low-income residents	410-836-8202 or 1-888-465-2468 (Mon–Fri 9–2:30), or online
Harford County Bar Foundation, 18 S. Main St, Suite 201, Bel Air	Judicare: a private lawyer for custody and divorce at reduced cost. Lawyer on the Line (Tuesday phone clinic) and Lawyer in the Library (monthly, rotating branches)	410-836-0123. Income up to 50% of MD median ($41,129 for 1; $79,094 for 4)
MVLS	Volunteer lawyers for custody, divorce, support	1-800-510-0050, Mon–Thu 9–12 (phone only for family cases)

Abuse and Protective Orders

SARC, 24-hour helpline 410-836-8430 (ask for the Legal Department; legal voicemail 443-371-3553, callback within 1 business day). Free attorneys for survivors of domestic violence, dating violence, sexual assault or stalking in protective orders, divorce, custody and child support cases, plus court accompaniment and safety planning. **Anna’s House** (Catholic Charities) shelters families facing abuse, 667-600-2840.

Child Support

Child Support Administration, 101 S. Main St, Suites 102 & 200, Bel Air. 1-800-332-6347; automated line 1-844-324-3855.

Mediation and Parenting Classes

The Office of Family Court Services (410-638-3100, 8:30–4:30) runs these programs:

- **Court-ordered mediation** by court staff is offered at no stated cost when the parents' combined income is under $150,000. Above that, it is referred to private mediators at about $200/hour.
- **Voluntary mediation** for parenting time is free, with no court order needed.
- Cases with abuse, safety concerns or a protective order are not sent to mediation.
- **Co-parenting class:** 6-hour online course, $25, with scholarships if you show low income. "Parenting Without Conflict" (12 hours, $25) for high-conflict cases.
- Also free when income qualifies: child access assessments, home studies and a children's support group. **Supervised visitation:** $70 intake, scholarships available (Visitation Center 410-322-8013).

Harford County Contacts

Need	Phone
Family Law Self-Help Center	410-638-4916
Family Court Services / mediation	410-638-3100
Maryland Legal Aid (local)	410-836-8202
Harford County Bar Foundation	410-836-0123
SARC (abuse, 24/7)	410-836-8430
Child support	1-800-332-6347
Child abuse report	1-800-917-7383
Department of Social Services	410-836-4700

Kent County, Maryland

Start at the **Family Law Clinic**, Kent County Courthouse, 2nd floor, 103 N. Cross St, Chestertown, MD 21620. It is free and walk-in. Kent uses the same Maryland laws, forms and fees as Cecil County. MVLS does not serve Kent County; use Shore Legal Access instead.

> *Casting all your care upon him; for he careth for you.*
>
> — 1 Peter 5:7

Court Self-Help

- **Family Law Clinic:** walk-in, first come, first served. Tuesday and Thursday 9 a.m.–noon, and Wednesday 2–4 p.m. Hours have varied, so call first. Income guidelines apply.
- A lawyer advises on divorce, custody, visitation, child support, modifications and name changes, gives you forms and makes referrals. Bring your papers and the other parent's address and phone number.
- **Phone help:** call 443-666-4327 during clinic hours to ask whether a lawyer can talk by phone. Tuesdays 11–12 are reserved for phone callers.
- **Maryland Court Help Center:** 410-260-1392 or live chat, Mon–Fri 8:30 a.m.–8 p.m.

Free Lawyers

Program	What it does	How to apply
Shore Legal Access (formerly Mid-Shore Pro Bono), 499 Idlewild Ave, Suite 102, Easton	Full representation in divorce, custody, support and visitation; weekly family law clinics	410-690-8128, Mon–Thu 9–4, or online. $25 application fee (ask in writing to waive it)
Maryland Legal Aid, Upper Eastern Shore office, 106 N. Washington St, Suite 101, Easton	Custody and domestic violence cases for low-income residents	410-763-9676 or 1-800-477-2543; statewide 1-888-465-2468
Women's Law Center Family Law Hotline	A lawyer answers questions anonymously	1-800-845-8550, Mon–Fri 9:30–4:30; Spanish 1-877-293-2507

Abuse and Protective Orders

- **Mid-Shore Council on Family Violence:** 24/7 hotline 1-800-927-4673; office 410-690-3222. Legal representation for protective orders, divorce and custody, court accompaniment, and a reduced-fee child custody project for low-income survivors.
- **For All Seasons** (rape crisis and counseling, Chestertown office at 315 High St): 24/7 hotline 410-820-5600; Spanish call or text 410-829-6143.
- **Kent Victim Witness Services:** 410-810-2264.

Child Support

Child Support Administration, 315 High St, Suite 208, Chestertown. 1-800-332-6347; automated line 1-844-324-3855. Mon–Fri 8–4:30. Parents who owe support may qualify for the **Mid-Shore RISE** job program (410-200-6261).

Mediation and Parenting Classes

The Family Services Coordinator (410-810-1059) runs the court's family programs:

- **Custody mediation,** when ordered, is free through Community Mediation Upper Shore. Day-of-court mediators are available on some days. Private property mediation may cost up to $400 a session, split between the parents; fee waivers may be available.
- **Co-parenting class:** online, $25 when court-ordered; fee waivers may be available.
- Monthly settlement conferences with a retired judge; also supervised visitation and home studies. Kent Family Center: 410-810-3790.

Kent County Contacts

Need	Phone
Family Law Clinic (during clinic hours)	443-666-4327
Family Services Coordinator	410-810-1059
Shore Legal Access	410-690-8128
Maryland Legal Aid (Easton)	410-763-9676
Mid-Shore Council on Family Violence (24/7)	1-800-927-4673
Child support	1-800-332-6347
Child abuse report	1-800-917-7383
Department of Social Services	410-810-7600

New Castle County, Delaware

Start at the **Family Court Self-Help Center**, 2nd floor, Leonard L. Williams Justice Center, 500 N. King St, Wilmington, DE 19801 (main line 302-255-0300, Mon–Fri 8:30–4:30). In New Castle County, free lawyers for divorce and custody are mostly limited to survivors of domestic violence. Everyone else can get a free 15-minute meeting with a lawyer at the courthouse, a fee waiver, and a $35 bar referral.

> *Fear thou not; for I am with thee: be not dismayed; for I am thy God: I will strengthen thee; yea, I will help thee...*
>
> — Isaiah 41:10

Court Self-Help

- **Limited Legal Assistance Program:** one free 15-minute meeting with a volunteer lawyer, no income limit. Family law sessions are Thursdays 11 a.m.–1 p.m. at the Self-Help Center. Appointment required: book at the 1st-floor Information Desk or call 302-255-0476. You must not have had help on the same issue before; the lawyer does not go to court with you.
- **Free forms and instructions:** online at courts.delaware.gov/family, or sold for a small fee at the courthouse. Custody: Petition for Custody (Form 345). Divorce: Petition for Divorce, Financial Declaration, and related forms.
- **Ask a Law Librarian** online chat: courts.delaware.gov/lawlibraries/chat.aspx.
- **Delaware Legal Help Link:** a free website that asks a few questions and points you to the right legal aid program.

Free Lawyers

Program	What it does	How to apply
Delaware Volunteer Legal Services (DVLS)	For domestic violence survivors: PFA orders; custody and visitation where there is abuse; first divorce papers (no property division or alimony)	302-478-8680 or 1-888-225-0582 (Spanish ext. 203), or the online intake form at dvls.org
Community Legal Aid Society (CLASI), 100 W. 10th St, Suite 801, Wilmington	Parents in Division of Family Services (DFS) cases — neglect, dependency, termination of parental rights; Elder Law (60+); Disability Rights Delaware. Its abuse unit refers New Castle survivors to DVLS	302-575-0660 or 1-800-292-7980, Mon–Fri 9–5
Delaware State Bar Association Lawyer Referral	A 30-minute first meeting with a private lawyer for $35	Online only at dsba.org

Legal Services Corporation of Delaware does not handle family law.

Abuse and Protection from Abuse (PFA)

- **24-hour domestic violence hotline:** 302-762-6110 (English and Spanish). Rape crisis (YWCA SARC) 1-800-773-8570.
- **Domestic Violence Advocacy Program at Family Court:** 302-255-0420. Advocates help you file a PFA petition.
- **File a PFA** in person 8:30–4:30 or by emailing the forms (PFA Petition, Form 450; Information Sheet, Form 240) to FC_PFA@delaware.gov. No fee. For a same-day emergency order, add Forms 656 and 654; requests after 3:30 p.m. are heard the next morning.
- **CHILD, Inc.,** 507 Philadelphia Pike, Wilmington, 302-762-8989: emergency shelter, safety planning, children's counseling.
- **YWCA Delaware,** 302-658-7110; Delaware Coalition Against Domestic Violence, 1-800-701-0456.

Child Support

Division of Child Support Services (DCSS), Churchman's Corporate Center, 84A Christiana Road, New Castle, DE 19720. Customer service 302-577-7171, Mon–Fri 8–4. DCSS establishes paternity and support orders and collects payments, and runs the **Delaware Fatherhood Program**.

Mediation and Parenting Classes

- **Mediation:** after a custody petition is served, the case normally goes to mediation first. Each parent must complete Form 364 (Custody Disclosure Report) beforehand. Mediation is skipped when there is a domestic violence finding or no-contact order.
- **Parent Education Class (required):** both parents in a custody case, and in a divorce with children, must take it. Cost is capped at $100 per adult; ask providers about financial help. Parents with a history of abuse take a special version. New Castle providers include CHILD, Inc. (302-762-8989) and Christiana Counseling (302-995-1680 x212).

Court Costs

- Divorce petition: $165 + $10 court security fee. Property division, alimony or a separation agreement: $90 each.
- No fee for a PFA.
- **Fee waiver:** file Form 257P, Affidavit in Support of Application to Proceed In Forma Pauperis (notarized) with your petition.
- To file for divorce, one spouse must have lived in Delaware at least 6 months.

New Castle County Contacts

Need	Phone
Family Court, Wilmington	302-255-0300
Free 15-minute lawyer (appointments)	302-255-0476
DVLS	302-478-8680
CLASI (Wilmington)	302-575-0660
Domestic violence hotline (24/7)	302-762-6110
Family Court DV advocates	302-255-0420
Child support (DCSS) / Fatherhood Program	302-577-7171
Child abuse report	1-800-292-9582

Lancaster County, Pennsylvania

Call **MidPenn Legal Services**, 1-800-326-9177, first, then use the **Self-Help Center**, 1st floor of the Lancaster County Courthouse, 50 N. Duke St, Lancaster, PA 17608, for forms. Custody and divorce papers are filed with the Prothonotary at the County Government Center, 150 N. Queen St.

> *Ere you left your room this morning,*
> *Did you think to pray?*
> *In the name of Christ, our Savior,*
> *Did you sue for loving favor*
> *As a shield today?*
>
> — "Did You Think to Pray?," *Hymns*, no. 140

Court Self-Help

- **Self-Help Center:** Mon, Wed and Fri 9 a.m.–1 p.m.; Tue and Thu 1–5 p.m. No phone. Staff do not give legal advice or fill out forms.
- **Packets:** "How to file for custody" is free to download or $10 at the center (Spanish available). Modification, contempt and relocation packets are $10 each. The In Forma Pauperis (fee waiver) packet is $1.
- File the original plus 2 copies with the Prothonotary, 150 N. Queen St.
- **PALawHELP.org:** free statewide legal information, a directory of legal aid by ZIP code, and guided forms for a custody complaint or modification.

Free Lawyers

Program	What it does	How to apply
MidPenn Legal Services, 38 N. Christian St, Suite 200, Lancaster	Custody and visitation, protection from abuse (PFA) representation and other family law for low-income residents. Survivors of domestic violence are helped regardless of income	Intake 1-800-326-9177, Mon–Fri 8:30–3:30, or online at apply.midpenn.org. Office 717-299-0971. Income up to 125% FPL
Lancaster Bar Association Volunteer Attorney Program	Volunteer lawyers for custody, visitation, support and domestic violence, working alongside MidPenn	717-393-0737
Lancaster Bar Lawyer Referral Service, 28 E. Orange St	A half-hour meeting with a private lawyer for $50	717-393-0737
Grandparents Raising Grandchildren Legal Line (SeniorLAW Center)	Free legal advice for kinship caregivers	1-877-727-7529

Abuse and Protection from Abuse (PFA)

- **Domestic Violence Services of Lancaster County** (Community Action Partnership): 24/7 hotline 717-299-1249; business line 717-299-9677. Protective-order help, court accompaniment, legal representation and clinics, and custody help, in English and Spanish.
- **YWCA Lancaster Sexual Assault Prevention & Counseling Center:** 24/7 717-392-7273.
- **File a PFA** at Bail Administration, Courthouse, 50 N. Duke St, 5th floor, 717-295-3584, Mon–Fri 8:30 a.m.–1 p.m. No fee.
- **PA SafeLaw:** 1-833-727-2335, free legal information and referrals for abuse survivors.

Child Support

Domestic Relations Section, Lancaster County Government Center, 150 N. Queen St, Suite 220. 717-299-8141; payments 877-727-7238. You can also apply online at childsupport.state.pa.us.

Custody Conference and Parenting Class

- **Custody conference:** after you file, the case is set for a conference with a Custody Conference Officer at the Courthouse, at least 10 days out. Questions: District Court Administrator, 717-299-8041.
- **“Focus on Children” seminar (required):** a 4-hour class run by Pressley Ridge at Lancaster Health Campus, 2100 Harrisburg Pike. Pre-register at 717-397-5241 and bring the certificate to your conference. Ask about the current fee.

- **Fathers:** Community Action Partnership’s Promoting Responsible Fatherhood program, 601 S. Queen St (717-299-7301).

Court Costs

Prothonotary fees (Dec 2025): custody complaint $177.75; custody with conference $272.50; no-fault divorce $237. E-filing adds $25. If you cannot pay, file the In Forma Pauperis petition ($1 packet at the Self-Help Center).

Lancaster County Contacts

Need	Phone
MidPenn Legal Services intake	1-800-326-9177
Bar Volunteer Attorney Program / Lawyer Referral	717-393-0737
Custody conferences (Court Administrator)	717-299-8041
Focus on Children registration	717-397-5241
DV Services of Lancaster County (24/7)	717-299-1249
PFA filing (Bail Administration)	717-295-3584
Child support (Domestic Relations)	717-299-8141
Child abuse report (ChildLine)	1-800-932-0313

Chester County, Pennsylvania

Call **Legal Aid of Southeastern PA (LASP)**, 877-429-5994, first. Custody and divorce papers are filed with the Prothonotary, Justice Center, 201 W. Market St, Suite 1425, West Chester, PA 19380, 610-344-6300 (8:30–4:30). Chester County has no walk-in self-help center, but it posts a complete custody packet for people filing without a lawyer.

> *...he hath sent me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives...*
>
> — Isaiah 61:1

Court Self-Help

- **Self-represented custody packet:** the instructions and forms cover the complaint, notice and order to appear, criminal record affidavit and entry of appearance.
- **Custody rules and forms:** chesco.org custody page.
- **PALawHELP.org:** free statewide legal information, a legal aid directory, and guided custody forms.

Free Lawyers

Program	What it does	How to apply
Legal Aid of Southeastern PA, 222 N. Walnut St, 2nd floor, West Chester	Family and custody law and PFA cases for low-income residents	Helpline 877-429-5994, Mon–Fri 9–1 (Spanish and 240+ languages), or apply online 24/7 at lasp.org/apply. Office 610-436-4510; no walk-ins
Chester County Bar Access to Justice Program	Free help with custody/visitation and no-asset divorce for residents just over LASP's income limit, or whose case LASP cannot take	610-692-1889
Chester County Bar Lawyer Referral Service	A first meeting with a private lawyer	610-429-1500, chescobar.org
Chester County Dept. of Aging Services legal consultations	Free 30-minute attorney consultations for low-income seniors, 2nd Monday each month	610-344-6350

Abuse and Protection from Abuse (PFA)

- **Domestic Violence Center of Chester County:** 24/7 hotline 888-711-6270 or 610-431-1430. Office 610-431-3546 (press 2 for legal services). Three staff attorneys represent clients at PFA hearings and may give advice and representation on custody, divorce and support. All free and confidential.
- **Crime Victims' Center of Chester County:** 24/7 line 610-692-7273. Protective-order help and court accompaniment.

- Temporary PFA petitions have no filing fee.
- **PA SafeLaw:** 1-833-727-2335.

Child Support

Domestic Relations Section, Justice Center, 201 W. Market St, Suite 3400, West Chester. 610-344-6215; Spanish 610-344-6638; info line 1-800-221-4636. Walk-ins Mon–Fri 8:30–3:30 (call ahead), or apply online at childsupport.state.pa.us.

Custody Conference, Mediation and Parenting Class

- **Conciliation conference:** set 10 to 90 days after filing, at the Justice Center, 5th floor, Hearing Room 5206. Family Court Administration: 610-344-6405.
- **Mediation orientation (required):** call your assigned mediator within 3 days of being served, or face a fine of up to $100. Mediators charge $100/hour, split between parents unless the court orders otherwise. The orientation is waived if a PFA covered either parent or the child in the past 24 months.
- **“Children in Between” class (required):** all parties must finish it within 30 days of the first filing. Take it online at online.divorce-education.com (choose Chester County; coupon code chester_parent) or in person on Thursdays at 4:30 p.m., Justice Center Room 3300.
- **Parenting support:** Family Service of Chester County — Exchange Club Family Center, 610-969-4900.

Court Costs

The last posted fee sheet (2023) lists a custody complaint at $213.25 and a no-fault divorce at $214.25, plus a $20 mediation fee per new custody or divorce case. Call the Prothonotary for current fees. If you cannot pay, ask the Prothonotary or LASP about a Petition to Proceed In Forma Pauperis.

Chester County Contacts

Need	Phone
Legal Aid of Southeastern PA helpline	877-429-5994
Bar Access to Justice Program	610-692-1889
Bar Lawyer Referral	610-429-1500
Prothonotary (filing)	610-344-6300
Family Court Administration	610-344-6405
DV Center of Chester County (24/7)	888-711-6270
Crime Victims’ Center (24/7)	610-692-7273
Child support (Domestic Relations)	610-344-6215
Child abuse report (ChildLine)	1-800-932-0313

Quick Reference

Phone numbers and hours change; call to confirm.

Emergency and 24/7

Need	Number
Immediate danger	911
National Domestic Violence Hotline (women and men)	1-800-799-7233 · text START to 88788
RAINN Sexual Assault Hotline	1-800-656-4673
Love Is Respect (teens, dating)	1-866-331-9474 · text LOVEIS to 22522
Human Trafficking Hotline	1-888-373-7888 · text 233733
Suicide & Crisis Lifeline	988
Any other need	211

By County

County	Abuse hotline (24/7)	Free legal help	Child support	Child abuse report
Cecil, MD	410-996-0333	410-996-1157 / 410-836-8202	1-800-332-6347	1-800-917-7383
Harford, MD	410-836-8430	410-638-4916 / 410-836-8202	1-800-332-6347	1-800-917-7383
Kent, MD	1-800-927-4673	443-666-4327 / 410-690-8128	1-800-332-6347	1-800-917-7383
New Castle, DE	302-762-6110	302-255-0476 / 302-478-8680	302-577-7171	1-800-292-9582
Lancaster, PA	717-299-1249	1-800-326-9177	717-299-8141	1-800-932-0313
Chester, PA	888-711-6270	877-429-5994	610-344-6215	1-800-932-0313

Statewide Lines

Need	Maryland	Delaware	Pennsylvania
Legal aid intake	1-888-465-2468	302-575-0660 (CLASI)	MidPenn 1-800-326-9177 · LASP 877-429-5994
Court help by phone	410-260-1392	302-255-0476	PALawHELP.org
Adult Protective Services	1-800-917-7383	1-888-277-4302	1-800-490-8505
Address confidentiality	410-260-3875	1-800-870-1790 (DOJ Victim Services)	1-800-563-6399
Victim compensation	410-585-3010	302-255-1770	1-800-233-2339
Kinship help	211 (text MDKinCares to 898-211)	302-255-9040	1-866-546-2111
Senior legal help (60+)	1-888-465-2468	302-575-0666	1-877-727-7529
Fatherhood / support job programs	410-200-6261 (Cecil, Kent)	302-577-7171	717-299-7301 (Lancaster)

Important Disclaimers and Sources

Please Read Before You Rely on This Guide

- **General information only.** This guide is for general reference. It is not legal, medical, financial, tax or immigration advice, and it does not create a lawyer–client, counselor–client or any other professional relationship.
- **No guarantee of eligibility or services.** Listing a program does not mean you qualify or that space, money or appointments are available. Each agency makes its own decisions.
- **Information changes.** Details were checked in October 2026 against official and organization websites. Phone numbers, addresses, hours, income limits and dollar amounts change often, sometimes without notice. Call to confirm before you travel, apply or make a decision.
- **Not an endorsement.** Organizations are listed only because they serve people in our area. The Wilmington Delaware Stake and The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints do not endorse, sponsor or take responsibility for any outside organization, its staff or its services.
- **Not an official Church publication.** This guide was compiled by local volunteers. Quotations from scripture, hymns, Church leaders and others are included for encouragement; you do not need to share any faith to use any resource in it.
- **Emergencies.** If anyone is in immediate danger, call **911**. For a mental-health or suicide crisis, call or text **988**. For anything else, dial **211**.
- **Not legal advice.** Family law depends on the specific facts and the state. Summaries of divorce grounds, custody, paternity, support, alimony and protective orders are general. Talk with a lawyer before you sign an agreement, move with children, or miss a deadline.
- **Deadlines.** Court deadlines are strict and missing one can cause you to lose rights. If you have been served with papers, act right away.
- **Confidentiality and safety.** Calls to hotlines and legal aid are generally confidential, but this guide cannot promise how any agency handles information. If you are worried someone is monitoring your phone or computer, use a safer device.
- **Church leaders and legal matters.** Bishops and other Church leaders can offer spiritual support and help with counseling and basic needs. They do not give legal advice and are not a substitute for police, courts or lawyers. Abuse must be reported to authorities as the law requires.

Found Something Out of Date?

Tell your ward or stake self-reliance specialist or your bishop so the next edition can be corrected.

Main Sources

- Maryland Judiciary (mdcourts.gov family law, Court Help Center, fee waiver form, name change); People’s Law Library; Maryland Legal Aid; MVLS; Harford County Bar Foundation; Shore Legal Access; Women’s Law Center of Maryland
- Cecil, Harford and Kent circuit court family services pages; The Bridge; SARC; Mid-Shore Council on Family Violence; For All Seasons; MCASA Sexual Assault Legal Institute
- Delaware Family Court (self-help, custody, divorce, PFA, fees, parent education); DVLS; CLASI; DSBA; Delaware DCSS (VAP, Fatherhood Program, modification); Delaware Fatherhood & Family Coalition; YWCA Delaware; Delaware DOJ VCAP; DSAAPD Adult Protective Services
- Lancaster County court self-help, Prothonotary fees, custody conference rules, Domestic Relations; MidPenn Legal Services; Lancaster Bar Association; DV Services of Lancaster County; YWCA Lancaster; Community Action Partnership
- Chester County Prothonotary, custody and mediation rules, Domestic Relations, Department of Aging Services; Legal Aid of Southeastern PA; Chester County Bar Association; Domestic Violence Center of Chester County; Crime Victims’ Center
- Maryland DHS Child Support (Payment Incentive Program, Mid-Shore RISE); Maryland Safe at Home; PA Office of Victim Advocate (ACP); PCV (VCAP, SAVIN); PA KinConnector; SeniorLAW Center; Women’s Law Project; EEOC (Pregnant Workers Fairness Act)
- National Domestic Violence Hotline; RAINN; 1in6; Love Is Respect; National Human Trafficking Hotline; StrongHearts Native Helpline
- General Handbook of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, 38.6.2; “The Family: A Proclamation to the World”